Through the Glass

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Tristan Chord

CH19603-01

Tristan Chord

Laplace Rehabilitation Center

Kakania: ...

Laplace Researcher: Ma'am, listen.

Laplace Researcher: Can you please put that down first?

Kakania: ...

Eyes empty, she ignores the researcher's tentative advice and continues to grasp the shard in her palm.

It's a shard of mirror.

Kakania: *deep breath*

Her mirror shattered during the "Storm." This is one piece of it.

But she can't recall who broke it.

Perhaps it was some frantic passerby or simply herself.

Kakania fights against her impulse to grasp the shard even tighter. There is already a cut in her hand. It would be best not to make it deeper.

The Foundation made a mistake. They failed to check her handbag for any dangerous items.

Foundation Staff Member I: Ma'am, the Foundation will accept you as a refugee in accordance with the "Storm" Act.

Foundation Staff Member I: And according to Article 43, Section 2, of the Act, "If a person has survived the 'Storm' with no obvious side effects, they will be put under quarantine control."

Foundation Staff Member I: It also says, "Under special circumstances, ask a member of staff involved in immunity protection production to intervene."

Foundation Staff Member I: So ...

Kakania: ...

Foundation Staff Member I: So we've invited Madam Lucy, the lead of immunity equipment production, to come speak with you. Please put down the sharp object and wait—

She's interrupted by the clanging of steel footsteps and a voice from outside the room.

Lucy: I have been informed that I am needed here.

Foundation Staff Member I: Madam Lucy! That was quick.

Kakania: Hm?

Kakania: Madam Lucy. Is that you?

The footsteps grow steadily louder until Madam Lucy is standing squarely in the doorframe.

Lucy: Yes. It is me. And you are ...

Her scanning process finishes within a second.

Lucy: Ms. Klara Vingler.

Kakania: That's right!

Kakania: We've only heard each other over the phone. I'm impressed you recognized me so easily!

Lucy: Your name is written on the end of the bed.

She points to the name tag. She had simply scanned the room.

Kakania: Oh, the name card. Of course. Haha.

The staff member nods and passes the file to Lucy.

Foundation Staff Member I: I'll leave her to you then, madam. And please be wary of the glass shard in her hand.

Lucy: Not to worry. A shard of glass cannot harm me.

She reaches out a shiny steel hand to Kakania.

Lucy: It is a pleasure to meet you, Ms. Vingler. You are the only one who made the knot and successfully survived the "Storm." I have many questions for you.

Lucy: Especially about your condition, side effects, and what it felt like in the throes of the "Storm."

Lucy: However, due to my suspension from Laplace, my colleagues will carry out the querying for me. Your answers will be of significant help to my research.

Lucy: As a time-traveler, you must have many questions for us as well. I will try my best to answer them for you.

Kakania: You're suspended?

Lucy: Is that your first question?

Lucy: The answer is yes. I received a suspension order because ...

The robot tilts her head, searching for the reason in her almost-ruined database.

Lucy: I violated the confidentiality agreement. I told an arcanist in Vienna about the knot. Her name was ...

Kakania: Kakania, I suppose?

Lucy: Yes, that seems to be the name.

Lucy: How impressive. We have never met before, yet you immediately filled the hole in my data. How did you do that, Ms. Vingler?

Kakania: Because I'm the one you told—I'm Kakania!

Kakania: What on earth is going on? Have you forgotten about our conversations on the phone?

Kakania: Good lord, just when I think I've found someone I actually know in this era!

Despite Kakania's increasing panic, Lucy remains remarkably calm.

Lucy: Do not worry, Dr. Kakania. My memory loss was an inevitable side effect of the "Storm" immunity experiment.

Lucy: The data I still have left should be sufficient to answer most of your questions, though some details will be missing.

Lucy: Are there any other questions you would like to ask me?

Kakania: Experiment side effects?

Kakania: I suppose the situation here is no easier than mine.

Realizing the sensitivity of the topic, she doesn't press for more details.

Kakania: "Immunity," you said.

Kakania: Ms. Marcus calls it a catastrophe, and you call it the "Storm." Is it some kind of disease?

Kakania: Like plague or smallpox?

Lucy: I am unable to answer this question. It is an unknown phenomenon. "Storm," "disease," and "immunity" are just terms we use to try and understand it.

Lucy: But an answer I can provide is: This is a disaster of time that covers the world. Only a few areas are unaffected by it. Both its origin and regularity remain unknown.

Lucy: Using the ritual provided by yourself and Investigator Marcus, we successfully found a method that protects people from the "reverse." Although it has its limits.

Kakania: That's it?

Lucy: That is the summary of the situation.

Even the person with the most knowledge on this subject has little understanding.

Lucy: Our research on "Storm" immunity is still in its initial stages. We are far from fully understanding it.

Lucy: Details like lineage, the thickness of pneuma where you cast the ritual, and the order you tie the knot may affect the results.

Lucy: It is necessary for us to cross-check our data with those who survived the "Storm." Furthermore, you are a crucial witness of the Vienna Incident.

Lucy: We hope you will cooperate with the examination and querying, Dr. Kakania.

Kakania: I understand, madam.

Kakania: I must thank you. Thank you again for giving me this opportunity. You kept your word and taught me how to tie the knot, but now I have almost nothing to give in return.

Kakania: I'm simply here as living proof that the possibility of survival is not zero. That's all I have to offer.

Kakania: I haven't a clue as to how or why it took effect. I'm afraid I'm useless to this place and to you.

Lucy: Is that so?

Lucy: Perhaps there is one thing you can do: undo the hypnosis on Ms. Dittarsdorf.

Kakania: Isolde?!

She jumps out of bed like a startled bird. Lucy just keeps talking.

Lucy: Since she is a former member of Manus Vindictae, the Foundation attempted to question Ms. Isolde von Dittarsdorf. However, she did not cooperate, or rather, could not cooperate.

Kakania: I-Is she alright? I was present for most of what happened, too. Maybe the Foundation can question me instead.

Lucy continues to ignore her.

Lucy: In brief, she has been in a state of hypnosis since she arrived at the Foundation. She still believes she is living a regular life in Vienna. Thus, we have made no progress.

Lucy: Investigator Marcus mentioned in her report that it was you who hypnotized Ms. Dittarsdorf.

Kakania takes a step back in horrified disbelief.

Kakania: No, it can't be!

Kakania: I hardly ever hypnotize my patients, and when I do, I'm extremely cautious about it. I didn't know it was even possible for hypnosis to last so long!

Kakania: No, I would never make such a rudimentary mistake! W-Would I?

Kakania: Oh, my! What have I done!

Lucy: We have adopted every known method to undo the hypnosis, but all have failed. We came to the conclusion that you used your arcane skill to hypnotize her. That is why we need your help.

Lucy: Can you undo her hypnosis by casting your arcane skill?

Kakania: I-I ...

She stares at Lucy, her breath rasping in her chest, unable to speak through the shock.

Lucy: Take a deep breath, Dr. Kakania.

Kakania: *panting*

Lucy: Relax. Try to control the pace of your breathing. Breathe in, breathe out.

Kakania: *panting*

Kakania: *panting* I, I ...

Kakania: I ... *inhale*

Kakania: *exhale* I can't.

Lucy: But you have taken a deep breath already.

Kakania: No, not that. It's my arcane skill.

Kakania: I can **no longer** use it.

Kakania looks down at the shard clenched in her hand. A drop of blood is running down her palm.

She forces herself to look up. With a bitter smile, she presents the shard to Lucy.

Kakania: As you said, experiments always have side effects. You lost something. So did I.

Kakania: My mirror is broken.

Kakania: Believe it or not, I cannot use it to cast my arcane skills anymore.

Empty Mirror

CH19603-02

Empty Mirror

Kakania stares through the doorway that Lucy left open.

The echos of their conversation are swimming in her mind.

"You cannot, or you do not want to?"

"Both. I can neither use my arcane skill nor do I want to."

"I can't control it, but, Isolde ..."

Kakania: Isolde ...

Kakania: I'm the only one who can help her.

"I'm the only one who can help her, aren't I?"

"Then ..."

"Just this once, I will try my best."

Kakania: I will ...

She bows her head.

Relax. It's just an arcane skill. Like you've cast countless times before.

It's the arcane skill passed down to you through the Vingler family—look into the mirror, and it will reflect whatever is on your mind.

Kakania: *exhale*

Kakania: Tell me.

Kakania: Um ...

It feels like a lifetime since she last cast her arcane skill. There's nothing in the mirror. It's as blank as her mind.

She doesn't even know what question to ask.

Kakania: For crying out loud! What am I doing?!

Kakania: This is ridiculous. It's not even a full mirror!

Kakania: How can I do anything with such a small fragment?!

Kakania: Such a small fragment.

Kakania: Fragment ...

Kakania: I need a new mirror. Something bigger and newer than this one, like, umm.

Kakania: A hand mirror?

Before she knows it, the shard in her hand has transformed itself into a hand mirror.

It's clear and familiar, but much too light.

Kakania: Hmm?

Kakania: This is ...

At this moment, she realizes that the mirror in her hand is simply an illusion. It plunges her into a fragment of her memory.

???: Welcome, my friend.

???: Here, this gift is for you.

Kakania: Oh, no, I couldn't possibly take this. I haven't done anything to deserve such a valuable gift.

???: Shh.

???: It's because of your help that I can now walk with you along the river! That arcanum license, though a forgery, is quite valuable to me.

???: So, please accept it. I'll be glad to be free from its whispers.

Kakania: Wait, it can talk? Zemfira, don't tell me you pulled this out of some ancient tomb or something!

Zemfira: Heh-heh. Take it, and then I'll tell you.

Kakania: You know, a hand mirror wouldn't be my first choice.

Kakania: The mirrors I use in my treatments can generally be placed independently, either on a table or the ground. This reduces the risk of them breaking during the session.

Kakania: ...

Kakania: It's a safety measure. Just to be sure.

Kakania: So, you see, I wouldn't know what to do with this, despite my desire to hear the story behind it. I always prefer table or full-length mirrors.

Kakania: They're safer, easier to place, and more convenient for patients.

Zemfira: I understand, my friend.

Zemfira: You're saying that this hand mirror is merely a gaudy plaything rather than a useful tool.

Zemfira: But when people first created the hand mirror, they were looking for simplicity and convenience.

Zemfira: In the end, though, they became rather meretricious. Attractive in appearance, yes. But of little practical use.

Zemfira: Just like arcanists, isn't it?

Kakania: I beg to differ.

Kakania: Arcanists aren't like that at all. We have much to offer the world.

Zemfira: Then you should take it.

Kakania: What?

Zemfira: Your arcane skill, so intriguing, yet horrifying. People, more than anything, fear their true desires being revealed.

Zemfira: So you need a container to hold all those overwhelming desires.

Zemfira: I know, I know. You already have two or three mirrors that are much wider and taller than this one.

Zemfira: But to have so many mirrors and not a single one to be held in the hand?

Zemfira: Well, the collection is incomplete, is it not?

Kakania: Not at all. It simply isn't necessary.

Zemfira: You don't have a hand mirror, how can that be? My friend, you simply must have a mirror.

Zemfira: A hand mirror for yourself.

Kakania: Well ...

Kakania: Alright, I'll take it. Thank you, Zemfira.

Kakania: Oh my, it's heavy. Has this been painted with tempera? And I must say, I don't recognize any of these patterns.

Kakania: Well, here it is. My very first hand mirror! A heavy, well-decorated, expensive medium for my treatment. Better put it away carefully.

Kakania: Actually, yes! I've made up my mind! I'll take it back and show it to everyone. I wonder what Elbert will say after I so vehemently refused to get a hand mirror all this time.

Kakania: Now, Zemfira, would you please tell me the story of this mirror?

Kakania: Hm?

She looks around. There isn't a single person to be seen.

Kakania: Zemfira? Where are you?

Kakania: Where did you go?

Kakania: Where's the mirror? Where's Zemfira?

???: You've come to the right man, Doctor.

???: Zemfira set off for the Caucasus some time ago. Didn't she tell you she was going?

Kakania: She ... Wait, Illich?

???: I heard she gifted you a talking mirror. Then, I'm sure you'll be interested in this, too.

???: It's a talking porcelain basin! If you wipe it down, fill it with clean water, and light it just right,

???: you can use it as a mirror as well!

Kakania: I'm sorry. What are you talking about?

Kakania: Or, rather, why are you here?

Kakania: In the Foundation?

Kakania: ...

Unable to answer such questions, the illusion is broken. It fades away, along with the mirror in her hand.

Slowly regaining control of her mind and body, Kakania returns to the ward once again.

She knows this will happen again. It's only a matter of time. All she can do is ...

Kakania: *exhale*

There's a file on the table. The Foundation has clearly expressed their requirements and suggestions within it, much like Lucy has told her.

Kakania: Help ...

As she scans through the file, Kakania comes to a decision.

Kakania: Yes, I need their help.

Kakania: To help her. To regain control of my arcane skill.

She presses the intercom button above her bedstand.

Operator: Laplace Rehabilitation Center, how may I help you?

Kakania: This is Klara Vingler.

Kakania: I agree to appear in court as a witness of the incident, and I will support the study of this "Storm."

Kakania: And I will also attend therapy.

Operator: I see. Please stay on the line.

Operator: We'll reroute you to our specialist to make the necessary arrangements.

In Deep Mud

CH19603-03

In Deep Mud

Mental Health Consultation Room, Laplace

Psychiatrist: Welcome, Ms. Klara.

Psychiatrist: I'm your attending psychiatrist.

Psychiatrist: Before we start the session, I'd like to confirm something.

Psychiatrist: What happened to make you lose control of your arcane skill?

Psychiatrist: Do you remember?

Kakania: ...

Memories flash before her, jumbled and messy.

She closes her eyes as she tries to recall.

Kakania: I ...

She's taken back to her days in Vienna.

Kakania: Zemfira, I ...

Zemfira: This is as far as you go, my friend.

Zemfira: We've walked a long way. You should head home. It's best not to be alone in the dark.

Kakania: What about you?

Zemfira: We enter the world alone, and we leave it alone. It's the natural way of things.

Zemfira: Don't worry, my dear Kakania. We'll see each other again.

Zemfira: I promise.

Kakania: But Russia is so very far away. Are you sure you'll still remember this place?

Zemfira: I will remember.

Kakania: May I at least walk you to the edge of town? There's a station there. I can take the tram back.

Zemfira: No need.

Kakania: I want to remember our last day together. Is it so awful to want to extend it just a little longer?

Kakania: Or is it because you don't want to see me anymore? If that's the case, I'll return the hand mirror you gave me right now.

Zemfira: It's because everything I wanted to say has been said. And the blessing has taken effect.

Zemfira: Simply looking at you makes me happy. It gives me hope to know there are still good people like you in the world.

Zemfira: That's why I gave you my blessing. As long as you don't break the mirror, you will feel its effects.

Kakania: What are you talking about?! Of course I won't break it!

Zemfira: Then please don't ever say that you'll give it back. And remember these words:

Zemfira: "**Disaster will fall on the shards of a broken mirror.**"

Zemfira: Don't forget.

Kakania: I won't. Although I still don't understand.

Zemfira: Ask no more, dear Klara.

Zemfira: You kept asking us wanderers what we wanted. You learned that Illich desires fortune and that Laurel longs for a life free from hiding.

Zemfira: But I haven't given you my answer yet.

Zemfira: What I'm looking for is ...

Kakania: ...

Kakania: What do you long for, Zemfira?

Kakania: And where is the mirror you gave me?

Kakania: My mirror, the hand mirror.

Kakania: It appears ...

Kakania: It appears that every time I think of it, either my memory or my arcane skill goes wrong.

Psychiatrist: I see. There's a close connection between your symptoms and your hand mirror. Noted.

Psychiatrist: Then, let's take a deeper dive into your mirror.

Psychiatrist: Could you describe it to me?

Kakania: Hmm.

Kakania: It's ornate. Finely decorated.

Kakania: But it's far more than an ornament. It's my very first hand mirror.

Kakania: And it shall never be broken.

Living Room, the Vingler House

Kakania: Elbert!

Kakania: Elbert!

Kakania: Look! My first hand mirror! My friend and I had a discussion, and I've decided to use it as a key element to improving my self-awareness.

Elbert: Klara! You're back!

Elbert: A hand mirror? May I have a look?

Elbert: Such a delicate mirror! It is perfect for your first hand mirror.

Elbert: "Your first hand mirror is for reflecting yourself. Your first table mirror is for observing others." The only thing missing is the Vingler family crest. You'd better present it to Father for his approval.

Kakania: Why should I? I have no need for his approval!

Elbert: Please consider it for me, would you, Klara?

Elbert: Father would so like to know about this. He's always wanted to understand you better.

Kakania: Fine! If I must, I'll show him the mirror. But I don't want his approval or the crest.

Kakania: I'll simply present it to him. I won't allow him to destroy it.

Elbert: *sigh* You can't keep doing this.

Elbert: You really should ...

Kakania: I already know what he's going to say.

Kakania: "You really should show more respect for Father."

Kakania: "You really should be more restrained. Don't disgrace yourself."

Kakania: "Stop associating with the lower class."

Kakania: "Act like a decent middle-class lady."

Kakania: "And become a part of this 'beautiful society.'"

Kakania: But ...

Kakania: Should I really?

Psychiatrist: Ms. Klara?

Kakania: I'm sorry. What are you talking about?

Kakania: Oh, my mind wandered again? Sorry.

Psychiatrist: No worries. It happens.

Psychiatrist: You were talking about the hand mirror and your brother, Elbert.

Psychiatrist: Is there anything else you want to share with me?

Kakania: ...

Is there? She asks herself.

Kakania: I don't recall where the hand mirror ended up. Perhaps it's broken.

Psychiatrist: People say that a broken mirror is a bad omen.

Psychiatrist: You've mentioned that it carries some kind of "blessing," though it sounds more like a prophecy to me.

Kakania: A prophecy, yes, of the disaster that would follow the breaking of the mirror.

Kakania: And it has come true.

Kakania: Because of that "blessing," Vienna is gone, and Elbert lost his arm.

Kakania: All because of that broken hand mirror.

Kakania: Like the one that broke in the "Storm"?

Psychiatrist: Actually, we don't know where the hand mirror is, and "prophecy" is just my personal understanding of it, not an objective truth.

Psychiatrist: So let's not jump to conclu—

Kakania jumps to her feet.

Kakania: You're right. It IS a prophecy. The mirror must be broken!

Kakania: That's why I can't do anything! It's because my mirrors are broken.

Kakania: All of them.

At the moment she buries her head in her arms, the mirrors in the room start to tremble.

They shake and crack, one after another, as Kakania falls back into her memories yet again.

Isolde: Ah!

Isolde: It's breathtakingly exquisite.

Isolde: It looks more like a frame for a delicate piece of art than a mirror.

Isolde: And look at the spider web detailing. Just gorgeous.

Kakania: ...

Middle-Aged Male: What is this thing?

Middle-Aged Male: It's pure blasphemy!

Middle-Aged Male: This is hardly a mirror, let alone one to be associated with the Vingler name! It's an utter disgrace!

Middle-Aged Male: **Klara Vingler! What do you think you're doing?!**

Kakania: ...

Her memories swirl in her mind, surrounding her like the fragments of broken glass that are now all over the floor. She sits with her head in her arms, her body shivering.

Kakania: Yes, the mirror is broken, just like ...

Kakania: Vienna is broken.

Kakania: ...

Kakania: What on earth am I doing?

Kakania: What on earth can I do?

A Wisp of Wind

CH19603-04

A Wisp of Wind

Therapy Room, The Foundation

Psychiatrist: Sorry, Ms. Klara.

Psychiatrist: You may have lost control of your arcane skill because of the trauma you've experienced. I should have focused on this in previous sessions; I missed it.

Psychiatrist: So, for the immediate future, we should keep you away from any mirrors or reflective surfaces until you overcome this disorder.

Psychiatrist: Do you agree?

The room has nothing but a pair of chairs and a table with a desk lamp. They sit across from one another.

Kakania: Yes, miss, uh, Doctor.

Psychiatrist: Alright. Let me explain the treatment plan the Foundation has created for you.

Kakania: ...

The psychiatrist keenly identifies that Kakania's mind has started to wander.

She taps the writing board with her pen.

Kakania looks up and blinks.

Kakania: Hmm?

Kakania: Oh, my mind wandered again? Sorry.

Psychiatrist: What's on your mind this time?

Kakania glances around the room, her eyes eventually falling on the dim, yellow lamp.

Kakania: Nothing. It's just this room reminds me of somewhere.

Kakania: I've been in one similar to this before. Back in Vienna.

Psychiatrist: What were you doing there?

Kakania: I was going to meet a friend.

Kakania: A friend, it seemed that I never really knew.

Psychiatrist: Would you like to talk about this friend?

Kakania: Sorry, I don't know where to start.

Psychiatrist: It's okay. Let's get back to our topic, then.

Psychiatrist: I'm sure you've noticed, Ms. Klara, that I've never stopped you from consciously or unconsciously recalling traumatic memories, as you did just now.

Psychiatrist: This is the initial stage of our treatment. We guide the patient to trace back their traumatic experiences in order to identify any causes and triggers of their disorder.

Psychiatrist: Then, through controlled exposure to these triggers, we start the process of desensitization, with the final goal being to help the patient create positive coping strategies to deal with these triggers.

Kakania: This treatment, it's quite different from the therapeutic strategies I'm familiar with.

Psychiatrist: In what way?

Kakania: For me, pushing patients to relive their traumatic memories is never good.

Kakania: And recalling trauma too frequently would only serve to damage the patient's psyche further—even exacerbate the isolation of these traumas in their mind.

Kakania: While free talk—and the more difficult conversations that stem from it—can be a useful tool to build trust, focusing only on trauma won't benefit anyone.

Psychiatrist: So you prioritize psychoanalysis. I see.

Psychiatrist: Remember the first time we met? You expressed your disagreement with the session arrangement.

Kakania: I still think that a weekly session is too infrequent for sustained psychological observation.

Psychiatrist: I understand, and as I've explained before, psychology has moved far beyond the exploratory stage of the early 20th century that you're familiar with.

Psychiatrist: Psychoanalytic therapy—"talk therapy," if you will—has seen many advancements throughout the century.

Psychiatrist: To be more specific, Laplace's psychotherapeutic method has long been separated from Freud's. Many of his theories have been proven wrong.

Kakania: ...

Kakania: I ...

This is not her era anymore. It has never been clearer than now.

She clenches her fist, and a sharp pain shoots from her palm. She looks down to see a blood-soaked shard clutched in her hand.

Kakania: This ...

Kakania: Hmm?

Psychiatrist: What are you looking at, Ms. Klara?

Psychiatrist: Ms. Klara?

Kakania: I—

Kakania: I'm hallucinating.

Psychiatrist: Thank you for telling me. What do you see?

Kakania: A fragment of a mirror.

Kakania: As I said, my mirror broke, and I haven't been able to use my arcane skill since.

Psychiatrist: Yes, the report stated that your arcane skill is related to mirrors—that they serve as a kind of "wand" for you. But it didn't tell me this.

Psychiatrist: What is it that you can do with a mirror?

Kakania: My arcane skill is "Vingler's Mirror." It allows me to see what people are thinking.

Kakania: You can understand it as reflecting people's inner desires into the mirror.

The psychiatrist takes a moment to contemplate this.

Psychiatrist: I see. This is how you treat your patients. So now, during our conversation, you fear I'm "prying" into you.

Psychiatrist: Because now you think that's what you did to your patients.

Kakania: ...

Psychiatrist: You no longer consider that treatment the right way of helping people, do you?

Psychiatrist: During our treatment, I'd like you to shift your understanding of yourself. You're not a psychiatrist in our sessions, Ms. Klara.

Psychiatrist: You're a patient who needs treatment.

Kakania: ...

Psychiatrist: To be honest, you're not the first psychiatrist I've treated. There are a lot of people at headquarters who have been traumatized by the "Storm," including some of my colleagues.

Kakania: How are they now?

Psychiatrist: Before I answer, I want to ask you a question. Have you heard about this theory:

Psychiatrist: "Growth is the process of behavior reinforcement."

Kakania: This sounds like behaviorism.

Psychiatrist: I thought you'd recognize it. Well, our method could be seen as a distant, less extreme evolution of behaviorism.

Psychiatrist: It's called "recognition reappraisal." We work with patients to identify and reframe the negative emotions they hold toward a particular traumatic event. Eventually, as they learn to better recognize and manage their emotions, the trauma will feel less overwhelming than it once did.

Psychiatrist: And to answer your question, most of my colleagues were able to modify their emotional response to the events that traumatized them through this process.

Psychiatrist: A small number of them are still under treatment because they haven't been able to reframe the negative emotions associated with their trauma.

Psychiatrist: Their friends didn't make it to the safe zone. Seeing the hands reaching out to them, the melted painting-like faces ... It keeps haunting them.

Psychiatrist: Much like how it haunts you, doesn't it?

Speechless, Kakania looks down again, opening and clenching her fist repeatedly.

There's nothing in it.

Psychiatrist: You unconsciously replay the events in Vienna before the "Storm" over and over in your head. And you keep mentioning that mirror. You relive those negative emotions again and again but are unable to reframe them—to understand them differently.

Psychiatrist: I'll need some more information in order to help you in this process.

Kakania: What do you need to know?

Psychiatrist: You identify yourself as a psychiatrist, and, outdated though it may be, you have a strong knowledge of psychoanalysis, yet you still use your arcane skill to treat your patients.

Psychiatrist: It sounds counterintuitive to me.

Kakania: ...

Kakania furrows her brow.

Kakania: You're right. It is counterintuitive for a psychiatrist.

Kakania: My arcane skill is one of my therapies. But there are many others I employ. All based on Dr. Freud's theories.

Kakania: I treat my patients with science. This arcanum is just a kind of parlor trick.

Psychiatrist: I see. A fusion therapy using an arcane skill and following Freudian theories could have some lasting value.

Psychiatrist: I wonder, have you ever used this on yourself?

Kakania: ...?

Kakania: What do you mean?

Psychiatrist: I mean, have you looked at yourself in your own mirror?

Kakania: I ...

Kakania: I'm sure I must have, but—

Psychiatrist: Yes or no?

Kakania: It's not possible. I—

Kakania: "Your first hand mirror is for reflecting yourself. Your first table mirror is for observing others."

Kakania: Every Vingler knows this.

Kakania: I had a hand mirror, so I must—

Kakania: I must have ...

Kakania: Have I?

Kakania: Have I looked at myself in my own mirror?

A Good Time

CH19603-05

A Good Time

Kakania: It reflects your inner thoughts, like a mind's endoscope. I cast an arcane skill on it to help your thoughts surface.

Kakania: Look at it, and tell me what you see.

Kakania: Have I?

Kakania: Did I ever look into it? Look into myself.

Kakania: Before it shattered?

Middle-Aged Male: What is this thing?

Middle-Aged Male: The color and design are vulgar, and I don't see our family crest on it. Such a hand mirror is unsuitable for a lady.

Middle-Aged Male: Even though the surface of the mirror is rather smooth, it simply cannot do.

Middle-Aged Male: Klara Vingler, you cannot take this as your first hand mirror.

Kakania: ...

Kakania: I neither seek your opinion nor your approval, Father.

Kakania: I'm simply here to inform you that I have my first hand mirror. There's no longer any need for you to give me one.

Kakania: That's all.

Elbert: No, wait—

Elbert: Father, it's a gift and a blessing from Klara's friend. I think that's why this hand mirror means so much to her.

Elbert: And you, Klara—

Middle-Aged Male: Her friend? What friend?! This isn't that damnable gypsy again, is it? Or one of those filthy arcane vendors, scurrying around in the shadows like rats?

Middle-Aged Male: No matter who it was, the moment you brought this thing into our house, it was a humiliation to me and to the whole Vingler family!

Middle-Aged Male: "Your first hand mirror"? Hah! Don't be ridiculous!

Middle-Aged Male: It isn't qualified to be a Vingler mirror. In fact, it tarnishes our very name! I warned you not to try to win my approval with an inferior product—

Middle-Aged Male: Inferior like your "friends"!

Elbert: Father! This is too much.

Kakania: Elbert, I've fulfilled my promise. I showed him, and from now on, this is my mirror.

Kakania: I'm leaving.

Elbert: Klara wait! Just a moment.

Middle-Aged Male: Wherever she's going, she cannot take that mirror with her. I won't allow it.

Middle-Aged Male: Take that thing away from her, Elbert!

Elbert: Father, please. Let her keep it, will you? You can give her another one as her first official hand mirror.

Elbert: She didn't mean to—

Middle-Aged Male: "She didn't mean to"?! She meant every word! She spends her life on her "career" and "ambition" and pays no mind to the shame it brings to this family!

Middle-Aged Male: As long as she continues to lead such a shameless life, my humiliation will never come to an end!

Elbert: Father—

Kakania: Haha.

Kakania: Arcane vendors like rats? Need I remind you how you made your fortune?

Kakania: If the Vingler name is truly as noble as you claim, then why do the gentlefolk of the upper class always decline your invitations?

Kakania: You've worked so hard, haven't you? To hide away your past as an arcane vendor and wear the mask of a noble man.

Kakania: Or, should I say, a noble human.

Middle-Aged Male: You—You—

Kakania: You know I'm right. I'm simply telling the truth.

Kakania: The more you try to distance yourself from your arcanist identity, the more people are reminded of it.

Kakania: When you criticize Mother for keeping in touch with her arcanist friends, you don't realize it's because YOU don't have any friends anymore, and somewhere deep inside, that stings.

Kakania: I pity you, to be honest. At least I have true friendship.

Middle-Aged Male: KLARA VINGLER!

Middle-Aged Male: What right do you have to accuse me?! You, who have dropped out of university, had multiple scandals with married women, and started an illegal organization?!

Kakania: ...

Middle-Aged Male: But you are right about one thing. It's not your patients who should be sent to the madhouse,

Middle-Aged Male: it's you!

Elbert: Father! Do we have to end it this way?

Middle-Aged Male: Take it from her, Elbert.

Elbert: Klara—

The servants block the door like silent statues.

She cannot leave unless she gives him the hand mirror.

Kakania: No need.

Kakania: I'll do it myself.

She raises the mirror high above her head and throws it to the ground.

It shatters as it collides with the floor. Mirror shards scatter around the room.

Elbert: Klara.

Her eyes are firmly fixed on her father.

Kakania: This is the last time I do as you ask, Father.

Kakania: ...

Kakania: Yes, it shattered.

Kakania: How could I see myself in it?

Kakania: I never even had the chance.

Kakania: It was destroyed, like the table mirror that shattered in the "Storm."

Kakania gives a weak smile, but soon freezes.

She sees the broken table mirror, sees the rain in Vienna.

Kakania: The hand mirror was too broken, Doctor.

Kakania: I couldn't see myself in it, so I decided to let it go.

Kakania: "It's insignificant," I thought. "There are far more important things to come!" How naive I was to not see ...

Kakania: Our society is broken, and like a mirror, it will keep shattering into ever smaller pieces.

Kakania: No one can put them back together on their own.

Kakania: So it is my duty, Doctor, to appeal to the people—to urge them to face the problems in our society, to do something to change it, to repair it.

Kakania: How ironic that, in the end, I would be the one to hasten the breaking of it beyond repair.

Kakania: Why me? Why did I survive?

Psychiatrist: I can see why you'd think this way.

Psychiatrist: But I think you keep saying this because ...

Psychiatrist: You're still blaming yourself.

Kakania: What else can I do?

Kakania: Take this shameful event for granted? Feel lucky and cheer for my "second life"?

Kakania: Why should a girl so full of sin survive? What about those innocent people who still had hope for life—who wanted to survive in this world? They turned to dust and were washed away by the "Storm."

Kakania: Why did they die? What was the meaning of it?

Psychiatrist: So you looked away because you couldn't face yourself in the mirror.

Psychiatrist: But you won't often find answers unless you look for them.

Kakania: ...

She hangs her head at this gentle accusation.

Psychiatrist: At least give it a try.

Psychiatrist: Take a look at yourself in your own mirror.

The Left and the Forgotten

CH19603-06

The Left and the Forgotten

Kakania: Have I looked at myself in my own mirror?

Kakania: I haven't because the mirror broke. Or did I do so before it shattered?

Kakania: And Zemfira's prophecy, did it come true?

Kakania: "Disaster will fall on the shards of a broken mirror."

Kakania: Disaster.

She struggles to search for any useful details in her cluttered mind.

Kakania: Umm.

Kakania: No.

Kakania jumps up from her chair, its feet screeching against the marble floor.

Kakania: I remember now.

Kakania: It did come true. Disaster struck.

Kakania: It was Elbert's arm.

Clinic

Kakania: What brings you here? You haven't recovered yet.

Kakania: And don't bother. I won't apologize.

Elbert: But ...

Kakania: But what? Why are you still trying to defend him?! It's because of him that you lost your arm!

Kakania: What on earth are you thinking?

Kakania: Those trust fund boys who try to disguise their bullying as "duels." Do you really think that changes the reality of their behavior?

Kakania: You know I won't sit idly by.

Elbert: I know, but I'm still sorry I didn't stop you.

Elbert: You can't keep doing this, Klara. It's unseemly to go around roughing people up with your friends from the street, and don't get me started on the horse manure.

Kakania: I just asked them to join me for a walk, as any lady would do.

Kakania: If one seldom walks on their own two feet, isn't it normal that one would occasionally trip and fall into some manure? Just blame the fact that horses are allowed in the park.

Kakania: Or are you suggesting that I bring them to my clinic and expose all their deepest, darkest secrets with my mirrors?

Elbert: No, I most certainly am not. Father was already angry about the incident with the hand mirror, and now this.

Elbert: You've messed with someone you shouldn't have. His family's reach extends to almost every corner of the affluent classes. It's affected our family business.

Elbert: Father is ... Well, he's furious now, and he may take his anger out on you. So, please, Klara. Come with me to apologize to Ethan before it's too late.

Kakania: I swear on my life, I have no idea who Ethan even is! I simply beat up a few fair-haired boys I didn't like.

Elbert: Klara!

Kakania: I said I wouldn't apologize, Elbert.

Kakania: Don't force me to do anything I don't want to, alright?

Elbert: No, Klara, I'm not forcing you. I know that will never work. I'm begging you.

Elbert: Just this once, alright? Just apologize, and everything will be fine. Father will forgive you, and Mother will be happy, too.

Elbert: I'm begging you, Klara.

That same old trick. He knew I couldn't say no to him.

But not this time. I had a way to shut him up.

Kakania: Then, can I beg for my hand mirror back?

Elbert: What?

Kakania: You clearly think if you beg me, I'll do as you wish.

Kakania: So if I beg you, will you repair and return my hand mirror to me? Exactly as it once was? If you do, I'll apologize.

Kakania: Well? Can you do as I wish?

Elbert: I, I ...

Kakania: You can't, can you?

Kakania: My mirror will never be the same. Nor will your arm.

Kakania: And that's why I won't apologize, Elbert.

Elbert: ...

I thought he'd give up after hearing this.

But, of course, he didn't. Soon after, he paid me another visit. Clearly, the security couldn't turn down a young man with only one arm.

Elbert: Hey, Klara.

Kakania: Elbert? Why are you here?

Kakania: Come in. Let's talk inside.

Kakania: But if you're here to persuade me to apologize to that man, then don't bother.

Elbert: No, actually, I've been thinking about what you said.

Elbert: And I'm here to show you something.

Kakania: What?

Elbert: Your hand mirror, remember?

Elbert: The one given to you by your Roma friend. The one you'd rather break yourself than give over to Father.

Elbert: You said that if I fixed it for you, you'd apologize.

Kakania: It's not possible! It was utterly destroyed!

Kakania: The glass shattered into pieces. How could you possibly put it all back together?

Elbert: Actually, I did it before you even asked me to. I tried my best to fix it, and I put it in an enamel frame. But I didn't dare give it to you until you said—

Elbert: Ahem. Anyway. It's your first hand mirror. Please, take a look.

He reached into the bag on his side and pulled out the mirror.

But before he could hand it to me, I stopped him. What I'd said before was nothing but a shameless taunt.

Kakania: Sorry, but this doesn't fulfill your half of the agreement.

Kakania: I'm still not apologizing.

Elbert: What?

Kakania: This isn't "exactly as it once was."

Kakania: Look at the cracks, and the frame, too. My hand mirror didn't look like this at all.

Kakania: A talking wash basin filled with water would do a better job than this. At least that would only show one reflection.

Elbert: A talking basin?

Kakania: Ahem, just a metaphor.

Kakania: In short, it's not so much a mirror as a sign of my failed rebellion. That won't change. No matter how well you fix it, Elbert.

Elbert: It's not like that.

Elbert: Klara, I repaired it because I wanted to give it back to you, not to make you apologize to Ethan.

Elbert: It's not a sign of failure, nor is it useless. This is your very first hand mirror and a gift from a dear friend.

Elbert: If it's truly so unimportant to you, then why did you bring it up back then?

Elbert: Take it back, Klara.

Elbert: And please, forgive me for not standing up for you when you confronted Father.

Kakania: ...

Kakania: It's meaningless, Elbert.

Elbert: I know.

Elbert: But we don't always live for meaning.

Kakania: ...

Elbert: "Your first hand mirror is for reflecting yourself. Your first table mirror is for observing others."

Elbert: You've helped so many people with the table mirror I gave you, and now,

Elbert: it's time for you to reflect on yourself.

Psychiatrist: At least give it a try.

Psychiatrist: Take a look at yourself in your own mirror.

Kakania: ...

Kakania: Elbert ... No, Doctor ...

Kakania: I ... *inhale*

Kakania: I still don't understand.

???: Ask no more, dear Klara.

The illusion's voice is familiar. It's warm and soft.

It is not the voice of any one person, but of many.

Kakania: What do you want, Elbert?

Elbert: I want you to be free and happy.

Elbert: As you want all people to be.

Kakania: ...

Kakania: What do you want, Zemfira?

Zemfira: What I want is your safety.

Zemfira: Those who speak out—who pursue their dreams through the tempest—won't flinch at their soaked clothes and the treacherous road ahead.

Zemfira: I don't want you to get hurt, Klara. I want you to be safe and sound.

Kakania: ...

???: You've asked many people the same question, but what's your answer? What do YOU want?

Kakania looks at the shard in her hand.

What do I want?

Kakania: What, then, is my dream?

The surface of the shard flickers, revealing a mirror reflected in it.

It's the mirror that was once broken, but now it appears whole again.

Kakania: ...!

The hand mirror that she once held so tightly.

The Day of Rebirth

CH19603-07

The Day of Rebirth

Kakania: This is ...

Kakania: I see.

Kakania: I remember it now. I've seen it before.

Kakania: ...

At that moment, when I took the mirror from Elbert's hand, I was almost burned by the heat of the handle.

I imagined him tightly gripping the mirror with the only hand he had left as he awkwardly stood at the door of my clinic.

That was not an image I wanted to see.

Kakania: Look at this thing! I can see the glue between the cracks, and these pieces don't even go together. You're really bad at this, aren't you?

Kakania: It looks like you've never once worked with your hands, er, hand.

Elbert: Klara!

Kakania: Why didn't you just take it to the factory and ask them to do the work? They're professionals. At least they could've coated the mirror with silver to cover the cracks.

Kakania: In its current state, my reflection is split and shattered, too. It's almost incomprehensible.

Elbert: But ...

Kakania: Pull yourself together and stop fidgeting! Be a gentleman, Elbert!

Kakania: And I will be a lady and keep my promise. Not to apologize, but to reflect myself.

I wasn't only talking to Elbert, but also to myself. It was an announcement.

I took a deep breath and tried to recall the feeling of casting my arcane skill.

But the mirror reflected nothing.

Kakania: Hmm, I don't see anything.

Kakania: That's odd.

Kakania: Or does this mean I have no desires? Interesting. Heinrich would like to know about this.

She studies her reflection between the cracks in the mirror.

Kakania: But it doesn't feel right. Perhaps because it was broken?

Elbert: Be patient, Klara.

Before he could finish his sentence, the image in the mirror twisted, revealing an object within it.

Though the cracks split it into many pieces, I could still recognize it.

Kakania: What is this? A new mirror?

Kakania: What do you mean?

Kakania: Is this my innermost desire?

Kakania: I, I saw it before.

Kakania: In the hand mirror Elbert fixed for me.

Kakania: I saw another hand mirror reflected in the shattered one.

Kakania: I thought my arcane skill didn't work, but upon reflection, maybe it did work. This must be the symbol of my dream, my desire.

Kakania: Back then, I wanted a new mirror.

Kakania: An independent, free kingdom. A new world for arcanists.

Kakania: Hah. A brand new world. I wanted it, and I got it.

Kakania: ...

Kakania: But this was never my intention.

Kakania: I've always tried to do something—to make a change. But what can I do if I can't even undo the hypnosis on my own patient?

She closes her eyes bitterly. When she opens them, her eyes are fixed on the shard in her hand yet again.

Moments before, when she cast her arcane skill, a mirror appeared in it.

The mirror covered in cracks and glue marks.

The mirror Zemfira gave her.

Kakania: Is this because I can't seem to shake the thought of this hand mirror, or is it another illusion of my arcane skill?

Kakania: My innermost desire, revealed by my arcane skill, is still the mirror given to me by Zemfira?

With Zemfira's name in her heart, she decides to try it again.

Kakania: Zemfira, you once prayed for my safety.

Kakania: So could you tell me if it's real? I shouldn't hurt myself to confirm its existence, should I?

Kakania: It's been an illusion so many times. It has to be real just this once, doesn't it?

She rubs the shard, trying to erase the image reflected within it.

No matter how hard she tries, the reflection remains firm.

She casts her arcane skill again, but nothing changes. The hand mirror, given by her friend, broken by herself, and put back together by her brother, still sits in its reflection.

Despite its repair, its cracks are still clearly visible. Like in life, no matter how much you heal, the damage will always be there.

Kakania: The cracked mirror ... How did I not see it?

Kakania: The marks here show it must've been shattered before.

Kakania: I know it's not new.

Kakania: I know it's not perfect.

Kakania: It's not even a very useful mirror.

Kakania: But still ...

Kakania: I wish so dearly for it to be in my hands.

A teardrop falls silently on the shard.

Kakania: I know that civilization is fragile, that life is fragile.

Kakania: But if life is destined to be broken, if society is doomed to be shattered,

Kakania: then we should at least try to repair it.

Kakania: Because we can't—we shouldn't—live in a broken society!

Kakania: This has always been my dream, from the very beginning.

Kakania: I just want everyone to find their happiness, to lead a harmonious life together.

Kakania: Why didn't I realize it sooner?

Kakania: Why didn't I tell Isolde, Elbert, and Zemfira? Why didn't I tell them earlier?!

Kakania: Why did I say those pompous, flowery things to Isolde instead of the simple truth?

Kakania: Why was I so cruel to Elbert when I could have expressed my joy and gratitude to have him as a brother?

Kakania: And, Zemfira. I was too young and naive to give her my encouragement—to express my wishes for her.

Teardrops rain down on the shard, running on its surface,

and gathering in the cracks of the hand mirror within.

Kakania: Why couldn't I fix Vienna?

Kakania: In the way Elbert fixed this mirror for me?

Kakania: ...

She's managed to regain her arcane skill, but it's not enough to fill the hollow in her heart.

Her friend can no longer hear her confession. The only thing left is this reflection of her gift.

Kakania: The prophecy of Zemfira. So then this mirror will not bring us disaster, rather, it has already protected us from one.

Kakania: She gave me this blessing, yet I lost her mirror. I lost the whole of Vienna.

Kakania: ...

Kakania: If only they could be here with me.

Kakania: If only I could touch this mirror again.

Kakania: If only ...

Kakania: I could fix everything.

A knock on the door pulls her back to reality.

Foundation Staff Member I: Ms. Kakania!

Foundation Staff Member I: We've been informed that you applied for an arcane skill experiment. We're here to take you to the field.

Foundation Staff Member I: Are you ready?

Kakania: What?

Kakania: Oh, I completely forgot.

Kakania: I've been spending so much time blaming myself that I ignored the most important thing.

Kakania: The thing that can be done by me, and only me:

Kakania: To bring together the broken pieces, to fix the mistake I made.

Kakania: To undo the hypnosis on Isolde.

She holds up the shard and looks at it through the light from the window. There's nothing in it anymore.

But Kakania knows there was a hand mirror in it, vivid and clear.

Kakania: Thank you, Zemfira. Thank you, Elbert.

Foundation Staff Member I: Ms. Kakania? Are you there?

The staff member opens the door and is startled to see Kakania already standing in the room.

Kakania: Yes! Thank you for coming.

Kakania: I'm almost ready!

Kakania: Is there anything else I need to do?

Foundation Staff Member I: Yes, here are the things to note:

Foundation Staff Member I: First, please remove any items that might damage yourself or the experimentation field, such as jewelry.

The Story of Tomorrow

CH19603-08

The Story of Tomorrow

Joint Committee of SF

Kakania: Sorry, I didn't ... What did you say?

Psychiatrist: It's okay. I'll repeat it for you. Please pay attention this time.

Psychiatrist: Laplace updated our diagnosis of Ms. Isolde's condition while you were receiving treatment.

Psychiatrist: We've determined that she's experiencing a state similar to post-traumatic stress disorder, one that is particularly persistent.

Psychiatrist: To put it simply, she's gone crazy.

Kakania unconsciously clenches her fist. It seems to have become her habit.

Kakania: Then her condition, it isn't because of my hypnosis?

Psychiatrist: No.

Psychiatrist: Even taking into account the unknown of your arcane skill, hypnosis couldn't achieve such a large shift in personality.

Psychiatrist: As it turns out, she was actually unable to cooperate with us, not unwilling to.

Psychiatrist: We're sorry, Ms. Klara. I understand you accepted the treatment in order to better control your arcane skill because of her.

Psychiatrist: But given her current condition, we strongly suggest you don't use your arcane skill on her, as it could stimulate her already unstable state.

Kakania: ...

Kakania: May I at least take a look at her?

Kakania: I've read through the visitation rules. I promise I won't make physical contact, nor will I pass her the mirror in case I cast my arcane skill.

Psychiatrist: That still poses considerable risk.

Psychiatrist: She seems to think she's still an opera singer living in Vienna. Before those family tragedies ever happened.

Psychiatrist: The Foundation staff guarding her are strangers, so they won't trigger her memories.

Psychiatrist: But you, you're different, Ms. Klara.

Psychiatrist: Your arcane skill, or even just your presence, might trigger her memories. Considering Ms. Isolde's arcane skill and the potential damage it might cause, triggering it will only raise her threat level, and we'll be forced to reduce the already limited freedom she has.

Psychiatrist: We're trying our best to avoid that.

Kakania: ...

Psychiatrist: Personally, I'd suggest against ...

Psychiatrist: breaking this fragile balance we've managed to maintain.

Kakania: ...

Kakania: Not even a single meeting? I just want to see her.

Psychiatrist: Maybe just once, as long as you promise not to try to dehypnotize her.

Kakania: I promise!

Psychiatrist: Then I'll submit a visitation request for you. The staff at the detention center will contact you about any follow-up procedures.

Psychiatrist: And you'll have to complete that rigmarole yourself.

Kakania: I understand.

Detention Center of the Foundation

Kakania stops at the iron gate of the detention center.

Foundation Staff Member II: Please fill out this visitor sheet, including your name, time of visit, and purpose.

Kakania: You know, in many ways, the Foundation headquarters remind me of Vienna.

Kakania: Especially in moments like this.

Kakania: All done. Here you are.

Foundation Staff Member II: Thanks for your cooperation. Please stand behind me. I'll open the door for you.

Foundation Staff Member II: You'll have to go inside alone. Remember, you have 30 minutes before the lights turn off. Once time's up, you need to come out as quickly as possible.

Kakania: Thank you.

Kakania: *exhale*

Kakania: After three rounds of procedures to obtain approval for the visit and discussions with four departments to allow me to bring personal items, I'm finally here.

Her voice gets quieter and quieter as she speaks.

Because she hears familiar, ethereal singing.

Kakania: ...?

Enthralled, she makes her way to its source.

It's Isolde. She's singing.

Isolde: ...♫

Not an aria, but the Tristan chord.

Isolde: Can you still hear them?

Isolde: They are out of my hearing already

Isolde: ...♪

Isolde: Anxious fears confuse your ear

Isolde: You are misled by the grove's whisperings

Isolde: Laughingly rustling in the wind

Kakania: ...

Isolde: The calling of horns does not sound so sweet

Isolde: It is the stream's gently murmuring waves

Isolde: Flowing along so gaily

Isolde: How could I hear that if horns were still calling?

Isolde: In the still of the night

Isolde: It is just stream that laughs with me

Isolde: He who is waiting for me

Isolde: In the silence of the night

Kakania: *exhale*

She softly responds.

Kakania: "That old tune ... Why does it waken me?"

Kakania: "Where am I?"

Kakania: "Where am I?"

Isolde: ...♪

Kakania: "I cannot tell you."

Kakania: "I was ..."

Kakania: "... where I had been before,"

Kakania: "and where I am destined to go."

Kakania: ...

She stops, taking a table mirror out of her bag.

This table mirror has attended countless treatments, including Isolde's. Its cracks are clear to see.

Kakania: This belongs to you, Isolde.

Kakania: **Goodbye.**

The stand makes a noise as she puts the mirror on the marble floor, yet it doesn't wake the lucid dreamer.

Isolde: ...

Isolde: Doctor.

Isolde: Listen, the fallen leaves rustle when you step on them.

Isolde: Isn't it just like a beautiful song?

There is no response but the sound of footsteps growing ever more distant. Footsteps that once echoed in the streets of Vienna, and will continue to echo in her dreams.

But not here.

Kakania: You said you had a personal opinion on Isolde's condition.

Kakania: May I ask what your opinion is? Why is she behaving like this?

Psychiatrist: When a person experiences trauma that is too severe to bear, they will often revert to a time when they felt the safest and happiest.

Psychiatrist: So I assume that, in her mind, time has been frozen in the best days of her life.

Isolde: If you've made up your mind and think I'm guilty, why do you treat me so gently?

Isolde: If this is the salvation you brought,

Isolde: I will embrace it with joy.

Isolde: Look, Doctor.

Isolde: The stars are shining.

Kakania: If you knew you were living in a dream made of lies, would you still embrace it?

Kakania: If this is the salvation you'd hoped for,

Kakania: I will accept it. If I must.

Kakania: ...

Kakania: Miss, you may close the door.

Kakania: I've ended the visit early.

Foundation Staff Member II: But you left your mirror behind. It's against the—

Kakania: I know, I know. I signed the agreement.

Kakania: But it's in the corridor, not her room. Could you at least leave it there for a day and take it away tomorrow?

Kakania: You can put it in my record as a member of the Field Agent Administration.

???: Ms. Kakania!

She turns toward the voice and finds a familiar figure standing by the other end of the gate.

It's Marcus.

Kakania: Hmm?

Kakania: Ms. Marcus! I didn't expect to see you here!

Marcus: I just returned from a field mission. I hurried over as soon as I heard you were here.

Marcus: But did I just hear that correctly? Have you joined the Field Agent Administration?

Marcus: There must be other choices. You don't have to—

Kakania: Yes, there are. But I've already decided. I will join the Field Agent Administration.

Kakania: I couldn't possibly work in government. That's never been my goal, and never will be.

Marcus: I wanted to introduce you to the Timekeeper before you made a decision. She also leads an independent team.

Kakania: But I've already made up my mind, Ms. Marcus.

Marcus: Umm.

Marcus: D-Do you know what kind of institution the History Maintenance Team is?

Marcus: I-I mean, its members and the missions they perform ...

Kakania: Yes, I'm fully aware. They're an expendable unit. Field agents can be abandoned at any time.

Kakania: The name explains itself.

Marcus: Would you give a second thought to meeting with the Timekeeper? Maybe after talking with her, you'll have another choice, and—

Kakania: I'd love to meet her! But only because she's a friend of yours.

Kakania: Perhaps, after meeting this friend who can forecast the "Storm," I can finally bid farewell to our old era and welcome this new one.

Marcus: I suppose your mind's made up, then ...

Kakania: We all have our responsibilities to bear, and this is mine.

Kakania: Our era was so brutally washed away. You saw it, too. And with the History Maintenance Team, I can do something to prevent the destruction of others' eras.

Kakania: It's the right thing to do, don't you think?

Marcus: Is this farewell?

Kakania: I've already said goodbye once, so no, it isn't.

Kakania: Though I cannot guarantee anything, there is a voice in my head that says:

Kakania: "One day, I will see you again."

Kakania: But this isn't the best place to chat. Let's go.

She points through the gate. Outside, the moon tenderly climbs up the sky.

She walks outside without looking back.

Kakania: After all, the path before us is the only way ahead.